

Chapter 98-1

Zhao Xuning tried to pull her arm back, only to find that Liang Shi's strength was greater.

.....

In that instant, Zhao Xuning decided to go to the gym after work today, and add an extra half hour of training every day from now on.

Liang Shi engaged in a battle of strength with her, then flicked her hair, trying to make herself look enchanting and seductive.

Zhao Xuning lowered her voice, speaking through gritted teeth, "Are you crazy?"

Liang Shi poked her waist. "I'm helping you."

Zhao Xuning: "....."

The words "What the hell" had already reached the tip of Zhao Xuning's tongue, but she forcibly swallowed them back down.

She let out a light breath. "You better be."

The whispered exchange between the two fell into Shen Hui's eyes, appearing particularly glaring.

Once upon a time, Zhao Xuning—cold and aloof in everyone else's eyes—had only ever had her by her side. Now there was someone else.

She would smile at someone else, would show different expressions to someone else.

Zhao Xuning, who had always been impatient, would accompany someone else to school, standing quietly by their side waiting for them to finish taking photos, would hold the door open for someone else.

Would rush over when someone else was in danger.

Would become someone else's emergency contact.

Shen Hui was no longer the most special person by Zhao Xuning's side.

She should have expected this, Shen Hui thought.

The moment they separated, they became strangers.

From then on, their marriages and futures would have nothing to do with each other.

The light in Shen Hui's eyes dimmed. She turned her face away, not looking at the two of them, and brushed aside the loose strands of hair by her ear.

Zhao Xuning hadn't closed the door when she came in. The early autumn morning wind was exceptionally cold and biting, turning her nose red and making her eyes somewhat dry. She was tired from staying up all night.

She still had to work at ten o'clock. The time she had now was only enough for her to go home, take a shower, and change clothes—she couldn't even catch up on sleep.

Thinking about this made her mood even worse.

Shen Hui pulled her coat tighter—it had been blown open by the strong wind—and walked straight past the two of them.

But Liang Shi called out, "Dr. Shen, don't leave yet. Xuning and I want to treat you to a meal, to thank you for speaking up for us last night."

Shen Hui: "No need."

She stood in place without turning around. Otherwise, she would have seen Zhao Xuning gazing deeply at her retreating figure, and the hand she had unconsciously reached out, wanting to hold her back.

Shen Hui's voice was even more cold and biting than the early autumn morning wind. "You two go ahead and eat. I wish you a hundred years of happiness together."

It's time to let myself go, Shen Hui thought.

She sniffled. Her thin silhouette looked lonely and desolate, making anyone who saw it feel heartache.

"Shen Hui." Zhao Xuning called out. "I....."

Before she could finish speaking, Liang Shi pinched her. Then Liang Shi ran in front of Shen Hui. "Dr. Shen, please don't leave yet. I have something to say to you—something really important."

Then Liang Shi asked Zhao Xuning to go inside and help her pay the fine and sign the paperwork. The whole process was swift, completed in less than three minutes.

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When they came out, Liang Shi was still blocking Shen Hui's path.

The two stood there in confrontation. Shen Hui wasn't as tall as Liang Shi, so she half-tilted her head up to look at her. "I'm just an insignificant ex-girlfriend. I don't care about what's going on between you and Zhao Xuning."

"Well, I just want to tell you." Liang Shi stubbornly said, "Don't you want to see how happy Xuning and I are together?"

"I don't want to see." Shen Hui let out a light scoff. "You looked pretty happy when you were with your wife too."

Shen Hui shot her a disgusted look. "Just last night you were standing up for your wife, and today you're being all lovey-dovey with Zhao Xuning. You and Zhao Xuning really are a match made in heaven."

Liang Shi: "....."

"Huh?" Liang Shi's heart was already pounding nervously, but she still stubbornly replied, "Xuning and I are truly in love. You won't even give us your blessings—is it because you still have lingering feelings for her?"

Shen Hui: "....."

"How do you want me to give my blessings?" Shen Hui asked. "Should I record a Vlog for you two? Or wait until you get married and give you gift money?"

Shen Hui scoffed lightly. "I'd advise you to get divorced first, so you don't end up in prison for bigamy. Though even if you did go in, it wouldn't matter—Zhao Xuning could pull some strings to get you out."

Liang Shi: "....."

"Then Dr. Shen doesn't need to worry about that." Liang Shi acted in an affected manner. "Dr. Shen is so worried about Xuning—is it because you still love her?"

Shen Hui: ".....Get lost."

"You're this angry, which means you still love her." Liang Shi said, "Otherwise, why do you always speak to her so harshly?"

Shen Hui raised an eyebrow. Those light brown eyes looked straight at her, growing even more indifferent. "What does it have to do with you? Do you think that because your eyes look similar to mine, you're happy that Zhao Xuning fell in love with you? Do you think she really loves you? No. There's only one person she loves, and that's herself. Don't think too highly of yourself."

"So you think I'm your substitute?" Liang Shi said. "Then I'm willing to be a substitute. Since you and Xuning can't be together anymore anyway, I can stay by her side as a substitute for the rest of my life. If you have the ability, come back and steal her away from me."

Shen Hui: "....."

"She's all yours." Shen Hui sneered coldly. "It's something I didn't want anyway."

Liang Shi: "?"

Why wasn't this going the way she imagined?

Liang Shi shot Zhao Xuning a look, wondering how on earth she had offended the other woman.

Six years of dating, and they'd only been broken up for how long?

Every time they saw each other, there was clearly still love there. In all the corners where others couldn't see, Shen Hui still looked at Zhao Xuning with lingering attachment.

Liang Shi had seen it before. What misunderstanding couldn't be resolved by sitting down and talking it out?

Liang Shi decided to put in more effort for the two of them. "Zhao Xuning is so wonderful. It's really a pity if you don't want her. She's like an untouchable flower on a high peak¹ outside, but at home she's especially gentle."

Shen Hui: "Oh, everything you have now, I've already had. What are you showing off?"

Liang Shi: "But that's past tense, not present tense, and certainly not future tense."

"My future doesn't need Zhao Xuning in it." Shen Hui said coldly, then glanced at her watch. "If you want to show off how great Zhao Xuning is to me, let's end this here."

Zhao Xuning called out to her, "Shen Hui."

Shen Hui glanced at her—cold and distant—and said nothing. She turned to leave, but just as she turned around, she saw.....

Shen Hui suddenly smiled. She waved toward the entrance. "Hi, beautiful."

Xu Qingzhu raised an eyebrow at her and, in a rare moment of sweetness, said, "Pretty sister."

Liang Shi: "....."

Her body stiffened, and she slowly turned to look toward the entrance.

There stood Xu Qingzhu in casual clothes. She greeted Shen Hui first, then looked at Liang Shi.

.....

There was an awkward atmosphere in the air.

Zhao Xuning came over too. Xu Qingzhu asked, "Dr. Zhao, are you done? Can we go?"

Zhao Xuning nodded. "Mm, let's go."

"Pretty sister." Xu Qingzhu called to Shen Hui. "Let me treat you all to breakfast."

Shen Hui looked at her, then at Liang Shi, and then nodded. "Sure."

Liang Shi & Zhao Xuning: "....."

In that instant, Liang Shi wanted to find a crack in the ground to crawl into. On the way to the breakfast shop, Liang Shi secretly asked Xu Qingzhu, "When did you get here?"

Xu Qingzhu chuckled softly. "When you were telling Dr. Shen how happy you and Dr. Zhao are together."

Liang Shi: "....."

This was probably precious documentation of a massive public humiliation scene.²

Liang Shi still held onto a sliver of hope. "Then why didn't you call out to me?"

Xu Qingzhu chuckled softly. "Teacher Liang was acting so seriously, I got completely absorbed watching."

Liang Shi: "....."

"I was just trying to matchmake Zhao Xuning and her ex-girlfriend." Liang Shi explained with utmost sincerity. "I tried really hard."

"Yes, you tried hard." Xu Qingzhu patted her shoulder. "You tried hard to deliver the worst acting performance of your life."

Liang Shi: "....."

Xu Qingzhu smiled. "Dr. Zhao probably wants to grab a knife right now and silence you permanently."

From Xu Qingzhu's tone, Liang Shi detected not only passive-aggressive sarcasm but also schadenfreude.

Liang Shi tried to turn back to look at Zhao Xuning, only to see Zhao Xuning obediently following behind Shen Hui.

When Liang Shi looked over, Zhao Xuning raised her head and met her gaze, then made a throat-slitting gesture at her.

Liang Shi felt a chill on her neck and moved closer to Xu Qingzhu.

She couldn't help it—this was her first time doing something like this.

She hoped things would work out for Zhao Xuning.

Really.

From the bottom of her heart.

Liang Shi felt she had tried her best, it's just that... maybe... her efforts were slightly misdirected.

Zhao Xuning would understand, right?

Footnotes:

¹ "Untouchable flower on a high peak" (高嶺之花, gāolǐng zhī huā): A Chinese expression describing someone who appears cold, aloof, and unattainable—like a beautiful flower growing on a high mountain peak that ordinary people can only admire from afar but never reach.

² "Public humiliation scene" (社死現場, shè sǐ xiànchǎng): Internet slang literally meaning "social death scene." It refers to an extremely embarrassing situation where one wishes they could disappear from society due to the mortification.

Chapter 98-3

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The breakfast shop was packed with people. Four of them gathered around a small table.

Xu Qingzhu spoke first. "I've recently fallen in love with xiaolongbao.¹ Is that okay with everyone?"

Liang Shi immediately agreed. "I'll have the mushroom filling."

Zhao Xuning and Shen Hui just nodded, leaving the ordering to Xu Qingzhu.

Clearly, Xu Qingzhu hadn't been to places like this very often, but she just had this confidence that could command the whole room, giving people the illusion that she had been here many times and was extremely familiar with this kind of shop.

Seeing this, what else could Shen Hui not understand?

So they had been putting on an act for her earlier. No wonder every word had been a provocation.

Tsk.

Shen Hui sneered inwardly. Only after they sat down did Xu Qingzhu say, "Let me introduce myself first. I'm Xu Qingzhu. This is my wife, Liang Shi. I'm an Omega, and Dr. Zhao and I are... friends, I suppose."

The introduction was crystal clear.

Normal people wouldn't introduce their secondary gender when meeting someone.

Shen Hui looked at Liang Shi and smiled with her arms crossed. "And you? Miss Liang."

Liang Shi: "....."

She cleared her throat softly and braced herself to introduce herself. "I'm Liang Shi. This is my wife next to me. I'm an Alpha, and Zhao Xuning and I....."

Liang Shi paused. A belated sense of shame welled up in her heart. Especially facing the dual pressure of Shen Hui's and Xu Qingzhu's gazes, she chose to apologize first. "I'm sorry. I was just acting earlier. Zhao Xuning and I are purely friends—as pure as pure can be."

"Miss Liang's attitude toward friends is truly admirable." Shen Hui's voice was flat, revealing neither joy nor anger. "To be able to sacrifice this much for a friend—impressive."

Liang Shi: "....."

She felt like Shen Hui was insulting her, but she had no evidence.

Moreover, that sentence was very similar to Xu Qingzhu's style. It wouldn't feel out of place at all if Xu Qingzhu had said it.

"It's because I noticed there still seemed to be a little spark between you two." Liang Shi explained. "So I wanted to give you a little push."

Shen Hui said coldly, "You imagined it."

Liang Shi: "....."

Zhao Xuning sat to the side without speaking.

On this ordinary morning, it was the first time Zhao Xuning and Shen Hui had eaten breakfast together in three hundred days.

Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu sat across from the two of them. The breakfast shop was filled with the fragrance of congee. Steam rose and lingered in the air. People coming and going were chatting and laughing. The four of them ate their meal quietly.

Shen Hui finished first. Zhao Xuning frowned from beside her. "You're only eating this much?"

"Not hungry." Shen Hui answered.

Zhao Xuning pressed her lips together and picked up another one for her with her chopsticks.

When Shen Hui looked over, Zhao Xuning said softly, "Shen Hui, one last one."

This sentence took Shen Hui back to their university days. Neither she nor Zhao Xuning knew how to cook, and the two of them really weren't diligent enough to eat breakfast every day.

If they had been up late the night before, or if Zhao Xuning had been particularly rough with her, Shen Hui would definitely be hungry the next morning.

Back when they had just gotten together, whenever Shen Hui said she wanted breakfast, Zhao Xuning would insist on holding her for another round. The two of them always had endless energy in that room.

After they were done, Zhao Xuning would hold her and sleep, saying they'd go eat after waking up.

Either way, Shen Hui could never get her breakfast.

Then one time, when Zhao Xuning did it again, Shen Hui cried from hunger.

Zhao Xuning was asleep when she felt tears falling on her face. She wiped at them, only to discover that Shen Hui was crying.

Her voice just after waking was unbearably hoarse. She held Shen Hui in her arms, kissed her face, her hand gently caressing her waist, and asked softly, "Wife, why are you crying?"

Shen Hui wouldn't let her hold her or kiss her. She cried with hiccuping sobs. "I'm hungry."

Zhao Xuning said, "If you're hungry, just order delivery."

"I want dumplings from Cafeteria Seven."² Shen Hui said.

Zhao Xuning: "....."

The cafeteria didn't do delivery.

Back then, Zhao Xuning was so lazy. She absolutely didn't want to get out of bed to go to the cafeteria to buy food.

But Shen Hui's tears seemed endless. She said she wanted dumplings from Cafeteria Seven—she wanted those specific dumplings and nothing else would do.

Zhao Xuning grew impatient and snapped at her, "Why are you being so difficult?"

Shen Hui was stunned at that moment.

Footnotes:

¹ Xiaolongbao (小籠包): A type of Chinese steamed bun (dumpling) traditionally from Shanghai and the surrounding Jiangnan region. They are known for containing hot soup inside along with the meat filling, and are typically served in bamboo steaming baskets.

² "Cafeteria Seven" (七食堂): Chinese universities typically have multiple cafeterias on campus, often numbered. Students usually develop preferences for specific cafeterias based on their food quality or specialty dishes.

Chapter 98-4

A few seconds later, Shen Hui got up to get dressed. Her body was covered in marks left by Zhao Xuning's tormenting—especially on her shoulders and back.

Shen Hui often said Zhao Xuning was like a dog, always gnawing and biting in bed. Though her tongue was indeed quite skilled, flexible like a snake.

Shen Hui was also difficult in bed, but back then Zhao Xuning was willing to indulge her.

When she was difficult at other times, Zhao Xuning couldn't be bothered to indulge her.

So when Shen Hui got up and finished dressing, Zhao Xuning asked where she was going.

Shen Hui didn't argue with her. She just said sullenly, "To buy dumplings."

But she had been worn out too thoroughly the night before. It happened to be after Zhao Xuning had been hungover the previous night, so she had been many times rougher than usual. As a result, Shen Hui's hunger was also many times worse than before.

She really couldn't take it anymore. She was so hungry that she cried from feeling wronged.

When had she ever suffered this kind of grievance?

Moreover, Shen Hui's legs were still trembling as she walked. Zhao Xuning lay in bed watching, her heart aching. She reached over to the side of the bed for a hair tie, tied up her hair, and then called out to Shen Hui in that cool, cold voice of hers, "Come back."

Shen Hui didn't look at her. She said petulantly, "What for? You're not going to buy it for me anyway."

Zhao Xuning quickly threw on her clothes and directly princess-carried Shen Hui back to bed. She was so frustrated she bit Shen Hui's lip, then took off her clothes and covered her with the blanket. "My little ancestor,¹ you rest. I'll go buy it."

Lying in bed, Shen Hui said, "I want mushroom filling."

Zhao Xuning frowned. "That stuff doesn't smell good at all. I don't understand why you like eating it."

Shiitake mushrooms, cilantro—foods with "fragrant" in their Chinese names were all excluded from Zhao Xuning's diet.²

But Shen Hui really liked them. She also liked fennel.

When Zhao Xuning first met her, Shen Hui had introduced herself by saying, "My name is Shen Hui—the 'hui' from fennel."³

Although Zhao Xuning was complaining, she still went out to buy it for Shen Hui in the end. Then she didn't let her get out of bed, instead squatting beside her like a human table, serving her while she ate.

Shen Hui had a small mouth and couldn't finish one in a single bite. Zhao Xuning would feed the remaining half to herself.

Shen Hui said to her, "I thought you didn't like eating mushrooms?"

"After you've eaten it, I don't think it's so hard to eat anymore." Zhao Xuning said.

Shen Hui kicked her with her foot, saying she was stealing her food.

Zhao Xuning just smiled without saying anything.

Shen Hui said she wanted to eat, but she didn't eat much. When Zhao Xuning held food up to her mouth with chopsticks, she would shake her head and say she was full.

So Zhao Xuning would coax her. "Be good, eat one more."

And Shen Hui would eat it.

Then one after another, until Shen Hui kept shaking her head. Zhao Xuning would coax her, "Wife, one last one."

Back then, she would always call Shen Hui "wife," "baby," "darling," "Huihui," "A-Hui"—all sorts of intimate nicknames.

Shen Hui liked to call her "Ningning," "Zhao Xuning," "Ningning wife," "Ningning darling"—whatever was most intimate.

No matter how angry Zhao Xuning got, she never dared to raise her voice when calling Shen Hui, and she never dared to call her by her full name.

Every time Zhao Xuning called Shen Hui by her full name was in bed, in the heat of passion. She liked to press close to Shen Hui's ear and whisper, "Shen Hui, I love you so much."

She would only be like this after drinking too much—always lingering and romantic, her tone tender as she spoke the two characters "Shen Hui."

It made Shen Hui want to kiss her so badly, and then the two of them would begin their wanton activities.

That day, after Shen Hui had eaten her fill, Zhao Xuning cleaned up the mess and returned to bed. Shen Hui burrowed into her arms. Zhao Xuning was so exasperated she bit her nose. "So I can't even call you difficult now?"

Shen Hui whined softly in a spoiled manner. "I was starving and feeling so wronged, and you're still criticizing me."

Zhao Xuning laughed. "My wife is just difficult."

"Do you like it or not?"

Zhao Xuning held her tight, then gently bit her lip and said in a muffled voice, "If I didn't like it, would I have gone so far to buy you breakfast?"

Shen Hui smiled.

Later, Zhao Xuning bought breakfast for Shen Hui many times. Each time, when Shen Hui couldn't eat anymore, she would always coax her softly, "Darling, eat one more."

"Wife, one last one."

"....."

She had heard words like these thousands of times, but this was the first time she heard, "Shen Hui, eat one more."

Once upon a time, whenever the two characters "Shen Hui" came from Zhao Xuning's mouth, they were always followed by "I love you so much."

Now, everything had changed.⁴

Shen Hui was dazed for two seconds. Zhao Xuning directly held the food up to her mouth with chopsticks. Shen Hui instinctively opened her mouth and bit down, leaving half remaining.

Zhao Xuning kept holding it there.

Liang Shi had been eating breakfast guiltily when Xu Qingzhu reached under the table and pinched her waist. Liang Shi glanced at her, and Xu Qingzhu frantically signaled her with her eyes.

When she looked up, she saw Zhao Xuning acting as if she were serving an ancestor. While Shen Hui was chewing her food, Zhao Xuning was gazing at her with eyes full of deep affection, not daring to relax the movement of her hands at all.

That gaze was so intense it could practically draw threads between them.⁵

Footnotes:

¹ "My little ancestor" (祖宗, zǔzōng): A term of endearment (sometimes exasperated) used to address someone who is being demanding or difficult to please, implying they're being treated like royalty or a precious ancestor who must be catered to.

² In Chinese, shiitake mushrooms (香菇, xiānggū) and cilantro/coriander (香菜, xiāngcài) both have the character 香 (xiāng, meaning "fragrant") in their names, despite many people finding their actual smells unpleasant. Zhao Xuning is making a joke about how these "fragrant" foods don't actually smell good to her.

³ Shen Hui's given name 茴 (huí) is the same character used in 茴香 (huíxiāng), meaning fennel. This is a common way Chinese people introduce themselves—by explaining which characters make up their name using well-known words.

⁴ "Everything had changed" (物是人非, wù shì rén fēi): A Chinese idiom literally meaning "things remain but people have changed," expressing the melancholy feeling when familiar places or objects remain the same but the people or relationships associated with them have changed.

⁵ "Draw threads" (拉絲, lā sī): This expression describes an intensely lingering gaze, like melted cheese that stretches into threads when pulled apart. It suggests a look so full of emotion and longing that it seems to create a visible connection between two people.

Chapter 98-5

Liang Shi: "....."

Her feelings were complicated.

But could this be credited to her brilliant acting just now?

Liang Shi didn't know. She only knew she seemed to have been fed dog food.¹

Then she also picked up a piece and held it to Xu Qingzhu's mouth.

Xu Qingzhu: "?"

"What are you doing?" Xu Qingzhu said. "I'm already full."

"Eat one more." Liang Shi said softly. "Teacher Xu should get the same treatment that others get."

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

"You mean the treatment of watching Teacher Liang cheat on my good friend back then?" Xu Qingzhu leaned close to her ear and whispered. "Teacher Liang really is quite willing to sacrifice for Dr. Zhao."

Liang Shi: "....."

What had she done wrong to have to experience this kind of public humiliation scene so early in the morning?!

But Xu Qingzhu did take a bite. Half still remained on the chopsticks. Xu Qingzhu shook her head. "I really can't eat anymore."

Liang Shi looked at it, feeling it shouldn't be wasted, but... Xu Qingzhu had already bitten it.

"If you're a germaphobe, just throw that half away..." Before Xu Qingzhu could finish speaking, Liang Shi had already stuffed that half into her own mouth.

Xu Qingzhu pressed her lips together and said nothing.

As for Zhao Xuning and Shen Hui's side, the two were terrifyingly silent, yet they naturally gave off an aura that made others not dare to disturb them.

After Shen Hui finished eating that piece, Zhao Xuning still said softly, "You're too thin now."

Shen Hui glanced at her lightly. "You're not much better."

Zhao Xuning smiled bitterly. "Isn't that exactly what you wanted?"

Both of their voices were low. But Shen Hui seemed to have thought of something. After spacing out for a moment, her attitude toward Zhao Xuning wasn't as cold as before. Instead, there was an indescribable tenderness when she spoke, and the tense atmosphere between them vanished in an instant.

Shen Hui said coldly, "I never wished for my ex-girlfriend to die after we broke up."

"Even if you did, it wouldn't matter." Zhao Xuning said. "I brought it on myself."

"As long as you know." Shen Hui said.

The two chatted intermittently while Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu sat across from them watching.

Suddenly, Liang Shi couldn't help but speak up. "Why can't people who love each other be together? In this world, it's already so hard to find mutual love."

Zhao Xuning kicked her under the table, not wanting her to say anything more.

But Shen Hui glanced at her. "You look pretty smart."

Liang Shi: "....."

The implication being—didn't expect you to be this stupid.

"I just feel sorry for you two." As someone who had already died once, what Liang Shi felt most keenly was the unpredictability of life. So she wanted to encourage the two of them to love recklessly while they still loved each other. Otherwise, when one of them disappeared or died, that would truly be a lifelong regret.

"No one knows how long they'll live in this world, so why not do what you love?" Liang Shi said gently. "Love the person you love, do the things you want to do. If one day the person you love suddenly died, how regretful would that be?"

Although she was expressing her views, there wasn't a hint of preaching. It wouldn't make anyone uncomfortable.

For a moment, it actually made people follow her train of thought.

If someone you loved dearly suddenly disappeared from this world one day, you would probably be in pain and miss them for the rest of your life.

Nothing is more unforgettable than death.

Zhao Xuning suddenly looked at Shen Hui, but Shen Hui lowered her eyes, refusing to meet her gaze.

All four fell silent. It was Shen Hui who broke the silence first. "But some people never even got to see this world. I think that's the most regrettable thing."

"And I need to spend my whole life making up for that regret." Shen Hui added.

Her voice was cold, but there was a hint of heartache in it.

"A-Hui..." Zhao Xuning called out to her softly.

"Dr. Zhao." Shen Hui pulled herself out of her memories and said coldly, "We've already broken up. There's no need to call me so intimately. After all, you already have a lover."

Zhao Xuning tried to explain. "No..."

Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu were simultaneously surprised. How did they not know Zhao Xuning had gotten a new girlfriend?

But then Shen Hui looked at Xu Qingzhu. "Beautiful, find a new wife."

Xu Qingzhu: "Hm?"

"An Alpha who doesn't respect herself is like rotten cabbage." Shen Hui said. "You're so good. She doesn't deserve you."

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

Xu Qingzhu couldn't help but laugh.

"Oh, right." Shen Hui felt her revenge wasn't enough and continued speaking to Xu Qingzhu. "Miss Liang said her one true love is Dr. Zhao. I think you should grant their wish. With your excellent qualities, what kind of Alpha couldn't you find? If it really comes down to it, I'll go through a second differentiation and you can be with me instead."²

Liang Shi: "?"

"Sis." Liang Shi was shocked by her words and couldn't help saying, "Are you really trying to steal someone's wife like this? I'm still right here."

Shen Hui swept a flat glance at her. "Who's your sis? Stop randomly claiming relatives."

"I'm the same age as Zhao Xuning." Liang Shi said. "And I'm calling you sis purely to express my apology... I shouldn't have done that earlier. I'm sorry for hurting your heart that still loves Dr. Zhao."

Shen Hui: "?"

"Where did you get the idea that I still love her?" Shen Hui scoffed lightly, confronting her head-on. "Don't meddle in other people's relationship issues, thank you."

Liang Shi: "....."

She was starting to regret everything she had done this morning.

Shen Hui then said to Xu Qingzhu, "If you don't divorce her, I'd feel sorry for you."

Liang Shi wished she could cover Xu Qingzhu's ears right now. But Xu Qingzhu calmly looked at Shen Hui and raised an eyebrow with a smile. "Tell me more."

Shen Hui clicked her tongue. "Miss Liang said this morning that she and Dr. Zhao are the true love, and that her marriage with you is just a sham marriage with no feelings. You're not divorcing after all that? That doesn't make sense."

Liang Shi: "....."

She guiltily lowered her head, helplessly pressing her forehead. Under the table, she kicked Zhao Xuning, signaling her to quickly make Shen Hui stop talking.

If this continued, she felt like she was going to be bitten to death by Xu Qingzhu.

But then Zhao Xuning said, "I don't love her. She's the one who threw herself at me. Xu Qingzhu, I also think you should consider getting a divorce."

Liang Shi: "?"

.....

Liang Shi knew her friendship with Zhao Xuning was plastic,³ but she didn't expect it to be this plastic.

It was like a plate of loose sand—it didn't even need the wind to blow before it scattered on its own.

Great.

Liang Shi stepped on Zhao Xuning's foot under the table. But Zhao Xuning said expressionlessly, "Liang Shi, your acting is really terrible. I don't think the entertainment industry is right for you. Go find a factory job."

Liang Shi: "....."

Shen Hui added from the side, "Whether she works or not doesn't matter. The key point is that I think the beautiful lady should get divorced."

Liang Shi looked at Xu Qingzhu, her gaze innocent and aggrieved, as if saying—see how they're all bullying me?

Xu Qingzhu stifled a laugh, patted her shoulder, and played along perfectly. "So the secret about Teacher Liang and my sham marriage is finally out?"

Liang Shi: "....."

Footnotes:

¹ "Fed dog food" (吃狗糧, chī gǒuliáng): Chinese internet slang for being subjected to public displays of affection from couples, making single people or bystanders feel like they're being forced to watch others' romantic interactions.

² "Second differentiation" (二次分化, èrcì fēnhuà): In ABO dynamics, this refers to a rare phenomenon where someone's secondary gender changes or develops further after their initial presentation. Here, Shen Hui is joking that she (presumably a Beta or Omega) could differentiate into an Alpha to be with Xu Qingzhu.

³ "Plastic friendship" (塑料友誼, sùliào yǒuyì): Chinese internet slang describing a fake or superficial friendship that appears close on the surface but is actually fragile and insincere—like plastic that looks nice but breaks easily.

Chapter 98-6

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Liang Shi didn't even know how she walked out of that breakfast shop. Her heart was filled with mixed emotions.

Zhao Xuning went to see Shen Hui off. Liang Shi punched her in the back to vent her frustration.

When it was just her and Xu Qingzhu left, she dawdled as she got into the car. Xu Qingzhu didn't mention anything that had happened at the breakfast shop, only telling her to close her eyes and rest for a bit.

After a moment of silence, Liang Shi tried to speak. "Um... actually, I..."

"Don't explain. I understand." Xu Qingzhu said. "It's just a sham marriage. You weren't wrong."

Liang Shi: "....."

What exactly do you understand!

Then Xu Qingzhu added, "Teacher Liang, I don't think what you said was quite accurate."

Liang Shi: "What?"

"How is this a sham marriage?" Xu Qingzhu said. "At most, we're just roommates sharing rent."

Liang Shi: ".....No."

Hearing her say that, Xu Qingzhu suddenly pulled the car over to the side of the road. Her gaze fell lightly on Liang Shi. Her slender arm rested on the steering wheel, her fingers curled and tapping on it carelessly. She said flatly, "You weren't wrong. Why are you being so awkward about it?"

Liang Shi pressed her lips together. "But we're not in a sham marriage."

Xu Qingzhu raised an eyebrow. "Did I marry you?"

Liang Shi: "....."

Liang Shi said in a muffled voice, "No."

Xu Qingzhu smiled, but there was little warmth in her eyes. "So we're not in a sham marriage. We're roommates sharing rent. Thank you, Teacher Liang, for saving my face in public."

Liang Shi: "What I said earlier was to provoke Shen Hui. I didn't mean it that way..."

"I understand, I understand." Xu Qingzhu said. "Teacher Liang, stop explaining. The more you explain... mm..."

Before Xu Qingzhu could finish, Liang Shi suddenly leaned forward, her lips landing on hers.

Xu Qingzhu's pupils contracted slightly. She instinctively wanted to pull away, but Liang Shi's hand fell on the back of her head, deepening the kiss.

Liang Shi's kissing technique wasn't skilled. The few times she had kissed had all been with Xu Qingzhu.

Xu Qingzhu was always so passionate that she only needed to respond.

But this time, she was the one taking the initiative. She took the initiative to move closer to Xu Qingzhu, and when Xu Qingzhu looked at her in a daze, she said softly, "Close your eyes."

Xu Qingzhu closed her eyes and followed her lead.

Liang Shi nibbled on her lips but didn't go any further.

Her lips lingered and moved over Xu Qingzhu's. When Xu Qingzhu's tongue tip traced across her lips, trying to pry open her teeth, Liang Shi kept them firmly closed and gently shook her head at her.

It was just a simple kiss, yet it made Liang Shi's face flush completely red.

After a long while, she pulled away and sat back in her seat, breathing slightly heavily as she steadied her breath.

She took a tissue from the tissue box beside her and gently wiped the corner of Xu Qingzhu's lips, wiping away the moisture there.

She looked at Xu Qingzhu tenderly. Her voice carried a slight huskiness from their just-finished entanglement, making one's heart itch.

Liang Shi said, "Remember this feeling."

This moment—it's Liang Shi who's kissing you.